Lesson 29: Revising: Reviewing Your Essay and Peer Review

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 5.1 Reviewing Your Essay; 5.2 Completing a Peer Review.

In this lesson

You learn the difference between revising (improving your ideas) and editing (improving how you express them), and you revise your essay draft for unity, coherence, concision and word choice. The book's peer review becomes a self-review with its checklist, followed by a second review from your tutor; then you decide which feedback to use. Revising is where a first draft becomes a good university essay.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain the difference between revising and editing.
- Check a draft for unity and coherence, in separate readings.
- Cut wordiness and choose specific, formal words.
- Review a draft with the book's peer-review questions.
- Evaluate feedback by the purpose of the assignment and the audience.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
revise	take a second look at your ideas: add, cut, move or change information	delete off-topic sentences
edit	take a second look at how you expressed your ideas: words, grammar, punctuation, sentence structure, style	correct a verb form
unity	all the ideas in each paragraph and in the essay belong, in a logical order	no digressions
coherence	the ideas flow smoothly; the wording shows how one idea leads to the next	transitions within and between paragraphs
digression	an unplanned move away from the main topic	Tuyet's comments about the sales staff

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
wordiness	using more words than you need	"as to whether or not"
concise	short and clear, with no unnecessary words	"The Biology Department sponsors two major experiments."
cliché	an overused expression that has lost its meaning	green with envy, better late than never
connotation	the feeling a word carries	proud (positive), conceited (negative)
peer review	feedback on a draft from another writer	"Your peer reviewer is your first real audience."
constructive criticism	comments that help a writer improve	"Ask someone you trust for feedback and constructive criticism."
recursive	done again at several stages, not only at the end	Reviewing, like planning and drafting, is recursive.

Rules and explanations

Revising and editing

- When you **revise**, you look again at your **ideas**: you add, cut, move or change information to make them clearer, more accurate, more interesting or more convincing.
- When you **edit**, you look again at **how you expressed** your ideas: you add or change words and fix grammar, punctuation and sentence structure (Lesson 30).
- Be critical of yourself in a positive way: have high expectations and train your eye to see what needs fixing.
- To see your draft with fresh eyes: take a break (a few hours or a day); ask someone you trust for constructive criticism (here, your tutor); pretend you are one of your readers.

Unity and coherence

- **Unity**: every idea belongs and is in a logical order. When writers are rushed or tired, they drift from the controlling idea. Unplanned **digressions** usually harm writing: Tuyet deleted her complaint about the sales staff at an electronics store, because her paragraph was about televisions.
- **Coherence**: the ideas flow, and the wording shows how one idea leads to the next, within and between paragraphs.
- Read your draft aloud and note where you feel confused.
- Look for each type of problem in a **separate sweep**: read once for unity, and a second time for coherence.
- Transitions improve coherence. Hall and Wallace group them by purpose:

Purpose	Examples
sequence or time	at first, meanwhile, afterward, finally
position	above, beside, beyond, opposite
a conclusion	indeed, hence, in the final analysis, thus
continuing a line of thought	furthermore, additionally, moreover, in the same way
changing a line of thought	however, nevertheless, on the contrary, on the other hand
importance	above all, in fact, more important, most important
final thoughts	finally, last, most of all
all-purpose openers	admittedly, certainly, generally speaking, undoubtedly
examples	for instance, for example, specifically

On a printed draft, writers use a caret (^) to show where to insert an addition.

Clear and concise

Almost every first draft can be clearer and more concise. Look for:

- sentences that begin "There are ... that";
- unnecessary modifiers and repeated meanings ("famous and well-known");
- phrases that add little: *in terms of, with a mind to, on the subject of, as to whether or not, more or less, as far as ... is concerned*;
- the passive voice and forms of *to be*: a subject that performs the action, with a strong verb, is clearer;
- "which is" clauses that can become short phrases, and repeated words that can be combined.

Specific, appropriate words

College essays use formal English. The book's other examples are in Exercise 3.

- Avoid **slang** (kids) and **overly casual** language: a formal tone needs formal words.
- Avoid **contractions**: write *do not* for *don't* and *I am* for *I'm*.
- Avoid **clichés**, overused expressions that are empty of meaning (green with envy, better late than never).
- Check **sound-alike words** in a dictionary: allusion/illusion, complement/compliment, concurrent/consecutive, founder/flounder, historic/historical.
- Choose the **connotation** you want: *proud* is positive; *conceited* is negative.
- Replace **vague words** (people, nice, good, bad, interesting) with specific words or details.

Peer review, adapted for self-study

Writers are often too close to their own work: pride gets in the way, and a sentence that makes perfect sense to you may be "total gibberish" to someone else. Reviewing other people's writing trains you to

review your own. Reviewing is **recursive**: you can ask for feedback on an introduction before you write the rest.

You study alone, so do it in three steps:

1. **Self-review** your draft (or a model) with the book's questions, "Another Format for Peer Review" (the box "Questions for Peer Review" is a picture and is not in your material):
    - **Organization:** strengths and weaknesses; confusing parts; the most important point; broad to specific; every sentence supports the topic sentence and every paragraph the thesis; transitions; flow.
    - **Focus and style:** one subject throughout; the thesis as a promise ("In this paper, the writer will ...") and whether it is kept; the writer's position; a style that suits the assignment and the audience.
    - **Development:** a title that shows the topic and catches interest; an opening that draws readers in; a conclusion that brings the main points together, without new topics.
    - **Conventions:** grammar, spelling, punctuation and other mechanics.
2. **Tutor review:** paste the draft and ask your tutor to review it with the same questions, starting with one positive comment and one question for more information, as the book asks reviewers to do.
3. **Evaluate the feedback.** You do not have to use every suggestion. Accept or reject each one by two criteria: (1) does it support the **purpose of the assignment**? (2) is it appropriate to the **audience**? If the same comment appears again and again, act on it in future assignments too.

Psychology note: like Hall and Wallace, APA style prefers the active voice, but psychology writers use the passive when the person who acts is unimportant, especially in Method sections: "Participants were randomly assigned to two groups."

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic rhetoric often uses pairs of near-synonyms and repetition for emphasis. In English academic writing, this usually reads as wordiness: the book's "famous and well-known" becomes "well-known".

Practice

Skip the three exercises about Tuyet's paragraph in the lesson material: they depend on pictures of her drafts, which are not printed.

Exercise 1. Revising or editing?

1. Tuyet deletes her comments about the sales staff.
2. You correct a verb that does not agree with its subject.
3. You move a body paragraph so that the order is more logical.
4. You add an example to support a point.
5. You fix a spelling mistake and a missing apostrophe.

Exercise 2. Wordiness. Cover the "Revised" sentences in the lesson material and make these sentences concise. Then compare.

1. There are two major experiments that the Biology Department sponsors.
2. Two extremely famous and well-known consumer advocates spoke eloquently in favor of the proposed important legislation.
3. As a world leader in the field of green technology, the company plans to focus its efforts in the area of geothermal energy.
4. A report as to whether or not to use geysers as an energy source is in the process of preparation.
5. It might perhaps be said that using a GPS device is something that is a benefit to drivers who have a poor sense of direction.
6. The e-book reader, which is a recent invention, may become as commonplace as the cell phone.
7. My over-sixty uncle bought an e-book reader, and his wife bought an e-book reader, too.

Exercise 3. Word choice. Which principle does each expression break: slang, overly casual language, contraction, cliché, sound-alike words, connotation, or overly general word? Give a formal alternative for items 1, 2, 3 and 8.

1. bummer
2. girls and guys
3. haven't
4. face the music
5. council / counsel
6. arrogant (when you mean proud)
7. thing
8. hanging out

Exercise 4. Transitions by purpose. These transitions are in Hall and Wallace's full table in the lesson material. What purpose does each one have? as soon as, next to, all in all, besides the fact, yet, especially, least of all, granted

Exercise 5. Reviewing a thesis and a title. Tuyet's working title is "Digital Technology: The Newest and the Best at What Price?" Her thesis (Lesson 25) is "Everyone wants the newest and the best digital technology, but the choices are many, and the specifications are often confusing."

1. Paraphrase the thesis as a promise: "In this paper, the writer will ..."
2. Does the title show what the paper is about? Does it catch your interest?

Exercise 6. Using feedback.

1. Which two criteria should you use to accept or reject a suggestion?
2. Several readers say that your paper does not hold together well. What does the book suggest?
3. Why is it easier to find problems in other people's writing than in your own?

Speak with your tutor

- "Act as my peer reviewer. Here is my essay: [paste]. Use the headings Organization, Focus and Style, Development and Conventions. Start with one positive comment and one question for more information."
- "Here is my thesis: [paste]. Paraphrase it as a promise ('In this paper, the writer will ...'). Then tell me whether my body paragraphs keep that promise."
- "Here is a paragraph from my essay: [paste]. Point out digressions, wordy phrases, contractions, slang and clichés, but let me correct them myself."
- "You suggested [suggestion]. Help me decide whether to accept it: does it support the purpose of my assignment, and does it suit my audience?"
- "Check my answers to Exercises 3 and 5."

Writing task

Revise your complete essay draft from Lessons 24 to 28 into a second draft. (If you are starting a new topic, first write a short essay of four or five paragraphs on stereotypes or on a PSYC 110 topic such as stress and coping, then revise it.)

1. Take a break of at least a few hours.
2. **Unity sweep:** read the essay aloud. Mark any sentence that does not support its topic sentence or the thesis; cut or move it.
3. **Coherence sweep:** check transitions and links within and between paragraphs (Lessons 27 and 28).
4. **Concision and word choice sweep:** cut wordy phrases; replace slang, contractions, clichés and vague words.
5. **Self-review:** answer the four groups of review questions in writing about your own essay. Write one positive comment and one question.
6. **Tutor review:** paste your essay and ask for a peer review (see Speak with your tutor).
7. **Decide:** list each suggestion as accepted or rejected, with your reason (purpose or audience). Then revise.

Self-editing checklist:

- Every paragraph supports my thesis, and every sentence supports its topic sentence.
- My paragraphs are in a logical order, and transitions show how the ideas connect.
- My thesis makes a promise, and the body paragraphs keep it.
- I removed wordy phrases, unnecessary modifiers and repetition.
- I used formal, specific words: no slang, contractions or clichés.
- My title shows the topic, and my conclusion adds no new topics.
- I accepted or rejected each suggestion for a clear reason.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1 (1) Revising (unity: cutting information). (2) Editing. (3) Revising. (4) Revising. (5) Editing.

Exercise 2 (book: the "Revised" sentences)

1. The Biology Department sponsors two major experiments.
2. Two well-known consumer advocates spoke in favor of the proposed legislation.
3. As a world leader in green technology, the company plans to focus on geothermal energy.
4. A report about using geysers as an energy source is in preparation.
5. Using a GPS device benefits drivers who have a poor sense of direction.
6. The e-book reader, a recent invention, may become as commonplace as the cell phone.
7. My over-sixty uncle and his wife both bought e-book readers.

Exercise 3 (the categories are the book's; the alternatives for items 1 and 8 are not)

1. Slang: a disappointment.
2. Overly casual: men and women (book).
3. Contraction: have not (book).
4. Cliché.
5. Sound-alike words (a council is a group that makes decisions; counsel is advice).
6. Connotation (arrogant is negative).
7. Overly general word.
8. Slang: spending time (with friends).

Exercise 4 as soon as: sequence or time; next to: position; all in all: a conclusion; besides the fact: continuing a line of thought; yet: changing a line of thought; especially: importance; least of all: final thoughts; granted: all-purpose opener.

Exercise 5 (example answers)

1. In this paper, the writer will show that buying new digital technology is difficult, because there are many choices and the technical specifications are confusing.
2. Yes: it names the topic (digital technology), and the question "at what price?" creates interest by suggesting a cost or a problem.

Exercise 6

1. Whether the feedback supports the purpose of the assignment, and whether the suggested revisions are appropriate to the audience.
2. Take the comment seriously, in this paper and in future assignments: for example, review a list of transitions and connectors.
3. Our own ego (pride) does not get in the way, and with our own writing we focus on what we want to say rather than on how we express it.

My notes